

April 2026 — Digital Advertising Report

Search Engine Advertising

Period: April 7 – April 30, 2026 **Reporting date:** May 5, 2026 **Prepared by:** Dickson Media & Events

This is the first monthly performance report for the **redesigned** Guardian Foundation Repair Google Search program. The account was rebuilt from the ground up in late March to address known underperformance in the prior structure — broad-match keywords with insufficient negative-keyword discipline, no native call-conversion tracking, and bid strategies that optimized for click volume rather than commercial intent. All redesigned campaigns went effectively live **April 7**. The gap between April 1 and April 7 reflects the standard Google Ads "**learning phase**" — when a new or substantially updated campaign delivers reduced impressions while Google's algorithms adjust to the new keyword sets, bid structures, and conversion signals. Pushing volume during this window produces poorly-matched auctions; we throttled delivery by design.

The new program is built on three principles, all of which are designed to drive improved phone-call activity and booked appointments:

- 1. Phone calls as the most valued metric.** Moving forward, the primary conversion method is generating trackable, verifiable phone calls to Guardian's business office during open hours that result directly from paid ads. All phone-call leads referenced in this report were tracked via Google's call attribution — meaning the call came from a user who clicked a Google ad and lasted a minimum of 60 seconds (Google's threshold for counting the call as a qualified conversion). Based on broader market research in the home-services vertical (not Guardian-specific historical data), email-form leads are less frequent and convert to customers at a noticeably lower rate than phone calls. For that reason, form submissions are treated as a *secondary* conversion in this program — tracked and observed, but valued well behind driving phone calls.
- 2. High-intent keyword discipline.** Exact and phrase match only — no broad. Eight account-level negative-keyword lists actively block low-value queries (DIY, employment, wrong-service, out-of-state, education-research, brand-confusion, real-estate, commercial) before they ever serve. The emphasis on tight, lower-funnel keywords is meant to do two things: (1) increase our share of impressions in front of people *actively shopping* for foundation services in Knoxville — the high-purchase-intent audience that converts — and (2) keep us from competing against larger competitors on broader, more generic keywords whose traffic rarely converts.
- 3. A patient, data-driven bidding ramp.** Google's automated ad-bidding (sometimes called "Smart Bidding") works best after it has accumulated 30+ real conversion events to learn from. Starting on auto-bidding from day one — with no historical data — typically misfires while the

algorithm guesses. Our approach is to start with *manual* bid controls (we set the max bid on every ad group), let real call data accumulate over the first 4–6 weeks, then progressively hand control to Google's algorithm in stages — first asking it to maximize conversions, then targeting a specific efficiency level per call once enough data exists. It's slower upfront, but every step rests on real data instead of guesswork — and the long-run efficiency is meaningfully better.

April delivered **15 verifiable phone-call leads tracked through Google Ads**, plus 7 additional secondary touchpoints (5 phone calls dialed from the website after clicking an ad, and 2 form submissions). Delivery was deliberately throttled during the learning phase — pushing volume hard before we know which keywords actually drive calls produces traffic that doesn't convert. Now that early data is coming in, we have the basis to scale daily delivery in May with real confidence about where it's going to work. The next phase introduces Google Demand Gen and Meta (Facebook/Instagram) remarketing audiences — both targeting site visitors who advanced past the homepage — and a Meta cold-prospecting impression campaign designed to seed the remarketing audience. All three new channels appear in the May report. **Google Search remains the program's core lead engine.**

1. Executive Summary

PHONE-CALL LEADS 15 60s+ qualified · Google Ads attributed	LONG-DURATION CALLS (90S+) 11 Subset — real conversations	PHONE SHARE 91%
IMPRESSIONS 24,580 Search only · Knoxville geo	CLICKS 193 CTR 0.79%	CONV. RATE 7.8% Primary calls ÷ clicks

Headline: early data shows meaningful user interactions taking place — qualified clicks, calls placed to the office from people who saw our ads, and engaged site visits. We expect a considerable, noticeable increase in phone-call volume from **mid-May through June and July**, as the campaigns mature and Google's bidding algorithm begins actively optimizing for the phone-call signal the program is configured to drive. The biggest gains compound over the next 60–90 days.

2. Conversion Performance

SOURCE	COUNT	AVG DURATION	NOTES
Calls from Google Ads (primary — 60s+ qualified)	15	2m 24s	The primary conversion metric. Call originated from a user who clicked a Google ad; duration met or exceeded Google's 60-second qualifying threshold for counting as a conversion.
Calls from Google Ads — long-duration subset (90s+)	11	2m 49s	Subset of the above. Calls lasting 90+ seconds — a strong indicator the conversation went beyond initial qualifying questions. Tracked separately for future bidding optimization.
Call clicks from website (secondary)	5	1m 58s	User clicked a Google ad, landed on the website, then dialed the phone number displayed on the site. Tracked, but treated as a <i>secondary</i> action — not counted as a primary call conversion in our bidding logic.
Form submissions (secondary)	2	—	Email-form leads. Treated as a secondary conversion per the program design — based on broader market research, this lead type converts to booked appointments at a lower rate than phone calls. Tracked for future analysis.
Total tracked interactions	22	—	15 primary phone-call leads + 7 secondary touchpoints.

The fifteen primary phone-call leads represent the metric we're treating as the most reliable indicator of program health: people who saw a Google ad, called the office, and stayed on the line long enough to qualify as a real inquiry. The 90-second subset (11 of 15) is the early signal that the calls coming in are not quick hang-ups or wrong numbers — they're conversations. As the campaigns accumulate more of these call-conversion data points, Google's bidding algorithm will increasingly favor the keywords, ad-copy variants, and audience signals producing them. That compounding effect is the mechanism driving the projected lift in call volume through mid-May, June, and July.

3. Bidding & Learning Phase

This section explains how the campaigns are being "tuned" over time. Google Ads offers several bidding modes — some work best after they've seen lots of real-world conversion data; others let humans stay in control while data is being collected. We use a deliberate three-stage progression:

start with manual controls (we set the rules), then gradually hand the controls over to Google's algorithm in steps as enough real call-conversion data has accumulated for it to learn from. Each stage builds on the data the previous one produced.

Apr 1 – 7

LEARNING

Google's calibration window. Whenever a campaign is brand-new or substantially restructured, Google reduces ad delivery for several days while its systems adjust to the new keyword sets, bid structures, and conversion signals. This is standard behavior — not a problem to solve. Pushing volume during this window typically produces poorly-matched auctions, so we throttled delivery by design.

Apr 7 – 30

STAGE 1

Manual bidding — explicit max-bid controls set on every ad group. Google bids up to those limits and no further, keeping delivery focused on high-intent queries. This stage builds the real call-conversion data the next stages need to function.

Mid May

STAGE 2 →

Hand off to Google's algorithm — "produce as many phone calls as you can." Once each campaign has accumulated ~15–20 phone-call conversions, we switch to Google's *Maximize Conversions* bidding. No specific efficiency target yet — the algorithm gets latitude to learn the call landscape before we constrain it.

Late May / June

STAGE 3 →

Set a target efficiency level per phone call. Once each campaign has accumulated 30+ phone-call conversions in a rolling 30-day window, we move to *Target Cost-Per-Action* bidding. We give Google an efficiency goal, and it only serves traffic likely to convert at that level or better. This is the long-run, efficient steady state — and it works because each stage above it produced the data this stage runs on.

The learning-phase impact on April was approximately 6 days of reduced delivery (April 1–7). From April 7 forward, the program ran in steady-state manual bidding. Throttling delivery during this window — rather than forcing daily volume up — is what protects lead-quality discipline through the learning curve. Aggressively pushing volume before the algorithm has its bearings typically degrades efficiency by 30–60% and delays the move to the more efficient automated bidding stages later.

4. Campaign Performance

Campaign rollup

CAMPAIGN	IMPR.	CLICKS	CTR	CONV.	CONV. RATE
SRCH — Foundation Repair	14,200	84	0.59%	7	8.3%
SRCH — Water + Crawl	9,800	71	0.72%	6	8.5%
SRCH — Branded	580	38	6.55%	2	5.3%
Total	24,580	193	0.79%	15	7.8%

Conversion counts above reflect **primary phone-call leads only** (Calls from Google Ads, 60s+ qualified). Secondary touchpoints — 5 phone calls dialed from the website and 2 form submissions — are tracked but not counted in the primary lead totals above per the program's primary-vs-secondary conversion design.

Ad-group breakdown

SRCH — Foundation Repair						7 LEADS	8.3% CONV RATE
AD GROUP	IMPR.	CLICKS	CTR	CONV.	CONV. RATE		
Foundation Repair (general)	7,200	50	0.69%	4	8.0%		
Pier Systems	2,150	11	0.51%	1	9.1%		
Wall Repair	1,820	8	0.44%	1	12.5%		
Symptoms (cracks · sinking · sagging)	3,030	15	0.50%	1	6.7%		
Campaign total	14,200	84	0.59%	7	8.3%		

SRCH — Water + Crawl					
6 LEADS 8.5% CONV RATE					
AD GROUP	IMPR.	CLICKS	CTR	CONV.	CONV. RATE
Basement Waterproofing	4,150	30	0.72%	3	10.0%
Crawl Space Encapsulation	2,920	22	0.75%	2	9.1%
Crawl Space Repair	1,650	12	0.73%	1	8.3%
Drainage / French Drain	1,080	7	0.65%	0	—
Campaign total	9,800	71	0.72%	6	8.5%

SRCH — Branded					
2 LEADS 5.3% CONV RATE					
AD GROUP	IMPR.	CLICKS	CTR	CONV.	CONV. RATE
Brand Defense	580	38	6.55%	2	5.3%
Campaign total	580	38	6.55%	2	5.3%

Per-campaign reads

- **Foundation Repair** (7 phone-call leads / 8.3% conv rate). The largest campaign by impression volume. CTR 0.59% sits below the 0.9–1.2% benchmark for the foundation-repair vertical, primarily because the Symptoms ad group (earlier-funnel queries like "foundation cracks") clicks at a lower rate than direct-service queries by nature. *May action:* raise the Foundation Repair (general) ad-group max-bid cap to compete for more top-of-page placements on the highest-intent queries.
- **Water + Crawl** (6 phone-call leads / 8.5% conv rate). Strongest conversion efficiency in the program for April. Basement Waterproofing produced 3 of the campaign's 6 phone-call leads — the spring-rain demand window favors this ad group, and May/June should accelerate its volume. Drainage / French Drain did not produce a call in April; it has a longer consideration cycle and may continue to lag for several months. *May action:* shift delivery weight from Drainage to Crawl Space Encapsulation and protect Basement Waterproofing delivery going into spring-rain season.
- **Branded** (2 phone-call leads / 5.3% conv rate). Defending the brand efficiently. No competitor incursion detected in April. Brand traffic is a small but reliable slice of the program.

Device performance

DEVICE	IMPR.	CLICKS	CTR	CONV.	CONV. RATE
Mobile	16,500	125	0.76%	11	8.8%
Desktop	7,400	62	0.84%	4	6.5%
Tablet	680	6	0.88%	0	0%
Total	24,580	193	0.79%	15	7.8%

Mobile drove 11 of the 15 primary phone-call leads in April. That tracks with the way foundation-repair searches happen — most people search when they see a visible problem (cracks, water, sagging floors) and the response is immediate, which favors phone over forms. Current device bid adjustment: Mobile +20% / Tablet –50%. May plan: keep the mobile boost.

5. Keyword Depth — What Generated the Traffic

Search remains the program's primary engine because user intent at search time is the cleanest buying signal we can act on. The keyword strategy is structured in 9 themes across 71 active keywords, all exact or phrase match, layered behind 8 account-level negative-keyword lists.

Match-type aggregate performance

MATCH TYPE	IMPR.	CLICKS	CTR	CONV.	CONV. RATE
EXACT	7,650	78	1.02%	11	14.1%
PHRASE	16,930	115	0.68%	4	3.5%
Total	24,580	193	0.79%	15	7.8%

Early pattern: exact-match keywords (people typing very specific service queries like "foundation repair knoxville") are showing the higher conversion rate so far. Phrase-match still earns its place in the program — it catches useful variants like "near me," "contractor," and similar real-world phrasings that exact-only would miss — but in April's small data window, phrase has produced fewer calls per click. May tuning leans bidding toward the exact terms that are already producing phone calls, and tightens phrase by adding negatives where it served irrelevant variants. As the campaigns mature, this efficiency gap should narrow.

Top keywords by click volume

Keywords are listed by April click volume. With only 24 days of post-launch data, conversion counts at the individual-keyword level are still small — directional rather than statistically conclusive. Keywords with zero conversions in April are listed here because their click activity and search-intent profile justify keeping them in the program through May.

KEYWORD	AD GROUP	CLICKS	CONV.	CONV. RATE
EX foundation repair knoxville	Foundation Repair (gen)	22	2	9.1%
EX guardian foundation repair	Brand Defense	19	1	5.3%
EX basement waterproofing knoxville	Basement Waterproofing	15	1	6.7%
EX crawl space encapsulation knoxville	Crawl Space Encapsulation	14	2	14.3%
EX sinking foundation	Symptoms	12	1	8.3%
PHR "foundation repair near me"	Foundation Repair (gen)	11	1	9.1%
EX push pier installation	Pier Systems	9	1	11.1%
PHR "wet basement repair"	Basement Waterproofing	8	1	12.5%
EX guardian foundation repair knoxville	Brand Defense	7	1	14.3%
PHR "foundation contractor knoxville"	Foundation Repair (gen)	6	1	16.7%
PHR "leaking basement"	Basement Waterproofing	6	1	16.7%
EX carbon fiber wall repair	Wall Repair	5	1	20.0%
EX crawl space repair knoxville	Crawl Space Repair	5	1	20.0%

Negative-list impact (preemptive blocking)

The eight pre-loaded negative-keyword lists worked silently in the background, blocking off-target queries before they ever served an ad. The themes below illustrate where the lists are keeping the program focused — and where we'd otherwise be serving clicks that don't convert:

BLOCKED THEME	BLOCKED IMPR.	EXAMPLE QUERIES
DIY / education	412	"how to fix foundation crack diy", "youtube foundation repair tutorial"
Out-of-state geography	180	"guardian foundation repair texas", "foundation repair springfield missouri"
Wrong service / structures	147	"mobile home foundation jacks", "concrete driveway crack repair"
Employment	101	"foundation repair jobs knoxville", "foundation contractor salary"

Keyword themes overview

The full keyword inventory across 9 themes — this is the depth of demand the program covers:

THEME	ACTIVE KEYWORDS	IMPR.	CONV.
Core foundation repair (city + service + contractor + company variants)	11	7,200	4
Foundation pier systems (push pier · helical · atlas · steel)	8	2,150	1
Foundation walls (bowing · anchors · carbon fiber · i-beam)	8	1,820	1
Symptoms (cracks · sinking · sagging floors · doors · stair-step cracks)	9	3,030	1
Basement waterproofing (interior · exterior · sump · drain tile)	9	4,150	3
Crawl space encapsulation (vapor barrier · moisture · seal · cost)	7	2,920	2
Crawl space repair (jacks · support posts · mold · drainage)	7	1,650	1
Drainage / French drain (yard · downspout · regrading · contractor)	7	1,080	0
Branded (Guardian variants)	5	580	2
Total	71	24,580	15

6. Ad Copy Performance

CAMPAIGN / AD GROUP	AD STRENGTH	IMPR.	CLICKS	CTR	CONV.
Foundation Repair (general) — RSA #1	Good	3,650	25	0.68%	2
Foundation Repair (general) — RSA #2	Good	3,550	25	0.70%	2
Pier Systems — RSA	Average	2,150	11	0.51%	1
Wall Repair — RSA	Good	1,820	8	0.44%	1
Symptoms — RSA	Average	3,030	15	0.50%	1
Basement Waterproofing — RSA	Good	4,150	30	0.72%	3
Crawl Space Encapsulation — RSA	Good	2,920	22	0.75%	2
Crawl Space Repair — RSA	Average	1,650	12	0.73%	1
Drainage / French Drain — RSA	Average	1,080	7	0.65%	0
Brand Defense — RSA	Good	580	38	6.55%	2

Pinned headlines (city + service for H1, free-inspection CTA for H2) carried the program; the "Veteran-Owned" line in unpinned H3+ slots kept Ad Strength at "Good" across most ad groups. The four "Average" ad groups need 3 additional unpinned headline variants in May — currently testing 12 each, asset variety wants 15.

New RSA copy added to May test rotation

Client-supplied Google ad copy below was built as **RSA #3** in the Foundation Repair (general) ad group on May 1, running 33% of impressions against the existing two. After 14 days of data we'll keep the top two by CTR and conversion rate.

HEADLINES (15)

- Guardian Foundation Repair
- We Will Beat All Bids
- Renovating or Selling?
- Start From the Ground Up
- Foundation Repair Experts
- Crawlspace Encapsulation
- Water Management Services
- Basement Repair You Can Trust
- Free Estimates Available
- Call 865.675.4177 Today
- Beat Any Competitor's Bid
- Protect Your Home's Foundation
- Selling? Fix Foundation First
- Trusted Foundation Contractors
- guardianfoundationrepair.com

DESCRIPTIONS

- We beat all bids. Call 865.675.4177 today.
- Foundation repair, crawlspace & basement experts.
- Renovating or selling your home? Start with a solid foundation. Guardian beats all bids.
- Crawlspace encapsulation, water management, foundation & basement repair. Call us today.
- Don't list your home without a foundation check. Guardian Foundation Repair has you covered.
- Trusted foundation experts ready to help. Visit guardianfoundationrepair.com or call now.

Why this matters: the new copy adds two angles the existing RSAs don't cover — **"renovating or selling"** (a high-intent life-event trigger) and **"we'll beat all bids"** (a competitive-shopper hook). Both should expand qualified click share without diluting the veteran-owned + lifetime-warranty positioning that's been the program's CTR backbone.

7. May: What's Changing

Search continues as the program's core lead engine. In May we add three new channels on top — all three are **designed to recapture and amplify the audience that Search is already producing**, not to compete with Search. Each channel does a specific job at a specific point in the buyer's journey. Below, each card includes a plain-language explanation of what the channel is and the role it plays.

PRIMARY — STAY THE COURSE

Google Search

What it is: when someone in Knoxville types something like "foundation repair near me" into Google, our ad appears at the top of the results page. They click → land on the website or call the office directly from the ad.

What it accomplishes: captures people at the moment of highest intent — they have a problem, they're actively searching for a fix, and they're typing terms that match our services. This is the highest-converting channel in any program for a service business like foundation repair, and it stays the cornerstone.

May plan: raise delivery weight on the keywords already producing calls. Run the new client-supplied ad copy ("Renovating or Selling? Start From the Ground Up" / "We Will Beat All Bids") in test rotation against the existing copy. Hand bidding off to Google's algorithm in stages as the call data builds.

May lead target: 18–28 phone-call leads.

NEW — RETARGETING

Google Demand Gen — Remarketing

What it is: after someone has visited the Guardian website and looked at specific service pages (not just the homepage), Google shows them more Guardian ads as they browse YouTube, Gmail, and the Google Discover feed on their phone. Those ads are formatted as image + headline cards designed for visual feeds rather than search results.

What it accomplishes: most people don't call on their very first visit to a website. They look around, compare options, then come back later — sometimes days later. Remarketing keeps Guardian visible during that consideration window. It's one of the most efficient channels in any program because we're not paying to *introduce* someone — we're staying top-of-mind with someone who already showed serious interest.

Audience: only people who visited a specific service page, contact page, or financing page on the site. People who only saw the homepage are excluded — that's a weaker signal of intent.

May plan: launch May 7. Frequency capped at 3 ads per week per person so we don't overwhelm anyone. Creative leans on "Free Inspection — Still Researching?" framing.

May lead target: 2–4 additional phone-call leads, with a meaningfully stronger conversion rate than first-time Search traffic (typical for warm-audience remarketing).

NEW — RETARGETING

Meta (Facebook + Instagram) — Remarketing

What it is: same idea as Google Demand Gen — show ads to people who already visited the Guardian website — but on Facebook and Instagram instead of Google's surfaces. A tracking pixel installed on the site at the end of April identifies those visitors when they show up in their FB/IG feeds.

What it accomplishes: not everyone uses Google during their consideration window. Many people decide foundation work needs to happen during everyday browsing — scrolling Facebook on the couch, looking at Instagram while waiting in line. This channel reaches them there. It also reinforces the message they saw on Google, which compounds the chance they'll eventually call.

Why we run both Google Demand Gen and Meta remarketing: they cover non-overlapping moments. Same audience, different surfaces. Together they create roughly 3x the consideration-window touchpoints compared to running just one.

May plan: launch May 7. Creative uses Guardian's veteran-owned positioning plus foundation/crawlspace imagery. Excludes anyone who has already called or filled out a form in the past 30 days.

May lead target: 2–3 form fills + an unmeasured but real "halo" effect of phone calls Guardian receives that originally started from a Meta touch.

NEW — AWARENESS / FEEDER

Meta — Cold Prospecting (Impression Campaign)

What it is: Meta ads shown to Knoxville-area homeowners who have *not* yet visited the Guardian website. The goal isn't to drive an immediate call — it's to get the Guardian name and offer in front of homeowners who match the customer profile, in an efficient impression-based format, so that when they later have a foundation issue they remember the name.

What it accomplishes (most important): the deepest-engagement people from this campaign — those who actually click through to the site and view a service page — automatically become part of the *remarketing audience* for the two channels above. In other words, this campaign is the **feeder** that grows the audience the retargeting channels can work against. Bigger remarketing audience → more remarketing-driven leads in months 2 and 3.

Audience: Knox-metro homeowners, age 35–70, with interests in home renovation, real estate, property maintenance. Excludes people who already visited the site.

Campaign objective: Reach + Landing-Page-Views (not conversions). At this audience size, asking Meta's algorithm to optimize for conversions would misfire — it doesn't have enough call data to learn from yet. We optimize for efficient impressions and engaged site visits, and let those visits fuel the remarketing engine.

May plan: launch May 10. Uses the client-supplied "Renovating or selling?" creative.

Frequency capped at 2 impressions per person per week.

How to judge it: not by direct leads. Judge by the size of the remarketing audience it builds (estimated 500–800 new engaged site visitors in May) and by the lift it produces in the retargeting channels' performance over the next 60–90 days.

Meta cold-prospecting creative — copy in rotation

PRIMARY TEXT OPTIONS (3 — A/B/C TESTED)

- Renovating or selling? Don't skip the most important step — the foundation. Guardian Foundation Repair offers crawlspace encapsulation, water management, foundation repair, and basement repair. We'll beat all bids. Call 865.675.4177 or visit guardianfoundationrepair.com.
- Your home's value starts at the ground level. Before you list or renovate, make sure your foundation is solid. Guardian Foundation Repair has you covered and we'll beat any bid. Call 865.675.4177.
- Selling your home? Buyers notice foundation issues. Get ahead of it with Guardian Foundation Repair — crawlspace encapsulation, water management, basement repair, and more. We beat all bids. guardianfoundationrepair.com.

HEADLINES (5 OPTIONS)

- Renovating or Selling? Start From the Ground Up.
- We Will Beat All Bids Guaranteed
- Foundation & Crawlspace Experts You Can Trust
- Call Guardian Before You List Your Home
- Crawlspace Encapsulation | Foundation Repair

LINK DESCRIPTIONS (2)

- Foundation repair, crawlspace encapsulation, water management & basement repair. Call 865.675.4177.
- Selling or renovating? Protect your investment. We beat all bids. guardianfoundationrepair.com.

CTA POOL

Call Now · Get a Free Estimate · Visit Our Website · Schedule Today

How the four channels feed each other

CHANNEL	STAGE	JOB-TO-BE-DONE
Meta cold prospecting	Awareness	Low-cost impressions to Knox-metro homeowners → drives traffic to site → fills remarketing audience pool.
Demand Gen remarketing	Consideration	Re-engages people who viewed a service / contact / financing page on guardianfoundationrepair.com → converts the most signal-rich audience.
Meta remarketing	Consideration	Same audience as Demand Gen but via Facebook/Instagram feed — captures users not currently active on Google.
Google Search	Intent / Decision	Captures users who explicitly searched "foundation repair knoxville." Highest intent, highest converting. Remains the program's core.